pouring down, people angry and upset and the England team looking for another new coach. I look back now to that miserable afternoon and think: *Why couldn't we have changed our minds and had one more game there? One more chance to give Wembley the send off it should have had?*

As it turned out, with the delays to the new National Stadium, we could have done that. Instead, you just have to hope that England losing to Germany isn't the only memory of Wembley that people are left with. Better to remember the great FA Cup Finals and Euro 96 and winning the World Cup back in 1966. From a soccer point of view, of course, if we'd been told before the game in October 2000 that we were going to lose to Germany that afternoon but then go on to beat them like we did in Munich a few months later, every single one of the players would have settled for that. A lot had to happen to the England team first, though.

Really important international players, leaders and captains like Alan Shearer and Tony Adams, had come to the end of their England careers, or were just about to. There was a group of lads, including my generation of United players, who now had the experience of two major tournaments—and two major disappointments—behind us. Following us, there were lots of talented young players waiting for their chance. When Kevin left, everybody seemed to agree about what needed to be done to get England going again. Before Sven-Goran Eriksson was appointed, Howard Wilkinson looked after the team for a couple of games and then Peter Taylor came in as caretaker manager for a friendly away to Italy. Everybody was saying:

'Shake things up. Go with the young players.'

Maybe Peter knew he wasn't going to be in the firing line that comes with doing the England job full-time. More likely, that's just what he's like as a coach: he was the one who had the courage to change the makeup of the national team, to recognize what needed to be done and then to go ahead and do it no matter what the doubters said. All the young players who've come in since should remember that it was Peter who was the first to take the chance with a new generation of players. It wasn't that he gave out a lot of new caps. What he did was give the younger lads the opportunity to come together as a team. Sven's been a huge influence but Peter got things started. Personally, I owe him, too. And always will: Peter Taylor gave me the England captain's armband for the very first time.

I'd only ever skippered a side once in my career. During my first year at Old Trafford, I was captain of the youth team that won the Milk Cup in